

world in cyberspace that is inhibited by people who tweet). But there is a lot more to twitter than just sending out such 140 character long messages. Through twitter's powerful API, people have been able to do some quite amazing things with the little birdie. Here we'll take you through some of the basics as well as tricky tips that you can use to get the most out of twitter.

Understanding symbols

Anyone new to Twitter will see a lot of "@" and "#" being used. The former is a way to address your post as a reply to another user. So if you want to reply to a user by the name of "xxx", you will type "@xxx" followed by your message to the user. The latter is a hashtag. Hashtags are a way of grouping or segregating topics on twitter. Its a concept borrowed from IRC. You will have to follow "hashtags" for your hashtags to get indexed. Head over to hashtags.org to see how they manage these tags.

Expanding your twitter bubble

The trick to expanding your twitter followers is by following more people. Follow to be followed is the *mantra*. But you can't just go about following people randomly. One of the best tools to help you get started is Twubble. It simply finds other people who you're connected to and picks out people who you may like to follow (<http://crazybob.org/twubble/>).

Put feeds into twitter

RSS feeds can be automatically posted through your twitter account. Twitter's API allows for this though third-party sites such as yotwits.com and twitterfeed.com. All you have to do is get the RSS feed URL and enter it into these services along with your twitter account details. There are also certain predefined news feeds available that the web site will suggest. These will be divided according to category, such as, say Tech news. If you put this feed into your twitter stream, it will



Using twubble to increase followers

automatically tweet the latest tech news from your account at predefined intervals. One of the best uses of this is to put your last.fm tracks feed into your twitter account. So any new track you play is automatically tweeted. Yotwits does not need registration while twitterfeed does.

Twitter trends

Do you know what #Twanuvaad is? Neither did we, but suddenly everyone on twitter was talking about it for some time. You can head over to whatthetrend.com to find out about the latest topics that are trending on twitter. The web site also gives you a short summary of why the particular topic is trending. Twanuvaad, by the way, is the literal translation of Hindi movie dialogues to English posted on twitter.

Monitor specific topics

By using search.twitter.com you can search for and monitor specific topics that people are talking about. Once you give a search term, you can even set up a feed for it. This feed will let you know every moment when someone talks about your keyword. This is also very useful for companies.

Go beyond 140 characters

Some people find that 140 characters is too little space to get by. Twitser is a Firefox extension which lets you post

text longer than 140 characters (<http://shorttext.com/twitzer.aspx>). Once you install the extension, simply ignore the negative counter, right click anywhere on the page and click "Twitser Text". Your text is shortened and an extension link is created. If the one viewing the post also has the extension, the user simply has to right-click and say "De-Twitzer text" to view in the same place. Be careful with this one though; people don't like to read long boring lectures via twitter.

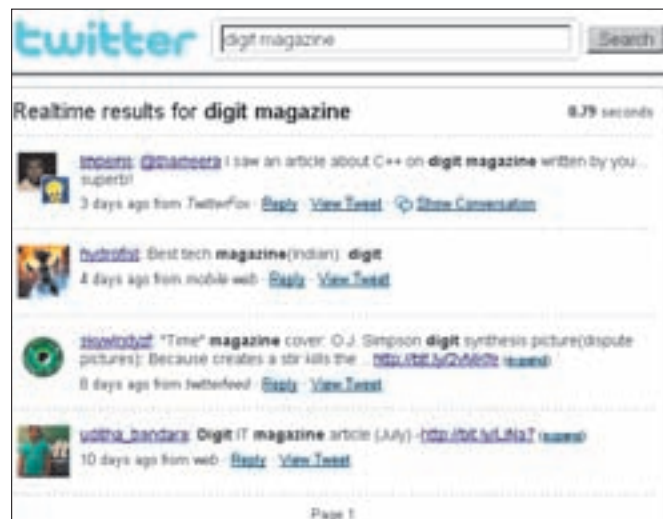
Tweet your photos

To tweet pictures from your flickr account you can use <http://flicktotwit.com>. It's a nice service that allows integration between your twitter and flickr accounts. You can upload pictures to

your flickr account from here, and give some text to go along. The text will automatically become a twitter update with a link to your photo. While you are linking the two accounts, be sure to complete the authorisation process carefully. Yahoo! will require you to authorise Flickr to access your flickr account. The other option for Firefox users is to use the flickr2twitter add-on. This one too is similar in terms of functions.

Use clients

Twitter applications such as Tweetdeck and seesmic are much better than using the twitter web page. Applications such as these allow for much greater functionality. For instance, Tweetdeck (which seems to be the favourite lately) gives you a subject and



See what people are currently talking about Digit on search.twitter.com